Ready for machine-speed attackers?

Trinidad and Tobago's banks and financial institutions in the age of AI-enabled hacking

Economic research | Shane Dante Bideshi | 28 October 2026

Executive assessment

Between 2024 and 2026, hacking changed. At first, attackers used AI as an assistant. Now AI agents can carry out most of an intrusion while a human supervises. In 2025, a group assessed as Chinese state-sponsored used an AI coding agent to perform an estimated 80-90% of an espionage campaign against about 30 organisations, financial institutions among them. In September 2026, one operator, relying mainly on inexpensive Chinese open-weight models with a US model coordinating them, compromised at least 27 companies in five days at about US$25 per target. In October 2026, South Korea's financial regulator confirmed that suspected AI-agent-driven attacks had hit 16 financial firms.

The Chinese and other open-weight models matter less because they are the strongest hacking tools. They are not. Government evaluators place the best of them roughly four to eight months behind leading US models on cyber tasks. They matter because anyone can download them, strip out their safety controls cheaply and run them where no AI company can monitor or stop them. US and UK evaluators found that one such model can already autonomously attack "small, weakly defended and vulnerable enterprise systems". **Much of a small country's financial system sits in exactly that category: credit unions, insurers, brokers, vendors and the outer systems of larger institutions.**

Trinidad and Tobago has already been hit repeatedly by conventional attackers:

- ransomware at TSTT, the National Insurance Board, the Attorney General's ministry, Massy Stores and Venture Credit Union;
- a chief-executive impersonation fraud that cost CIBC Caribbean's Trinidad operation about $14.8 million;
- deepfake videos of the Prime Minister and the Minister of Finance used to sell fraudulent investments.

No public evidence shows an AI-driven intrusion into a local bank, or a confirmed compromise of a commercial bank's core systems. That absence partly reflects how little is disclosed.

Judgment: Trinidad and Tobago's financial sector is not ready to defend against a determined hacker group armed with current AI tools. The largest banks are partly ready for routine attacks. Foreign parent groups, strong capital and a Central Bank incident-reporting rule that meets international timing norms all help. The system around those banks is not ready:

- The cybercrime law dates from 2000.
- The data-protection law has been only partly in force since 2011.
- There is no published supervisory response to frontier AI.
- No public incident statistics are published.
- The credit-union sector has no prudential or cyber supervisor.
- Customer security still depends on SMS codes sent over a two-company mobile market.

On this report's scorecard, overall readiness is **about 2 out of 5**.

Question	Finding
Has AI changed hacking?	Yes. Between 2024 and 2026 it moved from drafting phishing emails to running most steps of real intrusions. It mainly makes existing techniques faster and cheaper; it has not invented new types of attack.

Question	Finding
Do Chinese and open-weight models matter?	Yes, but not because they are the best. They are good enough, cheap, and beyond the reach of any company's safety monitoring.
Has an AI-enabled attack hit a T&T bank?	Not on public evidence. Locally, AI has so far appeared in deepfake investment scams. Losses have come from ransomware, impersonation and account takeover.
Are the largest banks prepared?	Partly, against common attacks. Public evidence shows SMS codes still in use and no confirmation-of-payee checks. One bank's board reports no director highly skilled in cybersecurity.
Is the wider system prepared?	No. The main gaps are laws, the speed of supervision, information sharing, incident data, shared infrastructure and the credit-union and insurance periphery.
What would most improve readiness quickly?	A Central Bank frontier-AI directive, a sector payment-verification standard, a rapid fraud-freeze protocol and published incident data. Each can be done within months without new legislation.

Scope and evidence: research completed 28 October 2026 using public sources only: regulator and government documents, parliamentary records, company reports, AI-developer and security-vendor threat reports, and news coverage. No institution's systems were tested and no confidential supervisory information was available. Ratings are analytical judgments. A public-evidence review can understate controls that institutions do not disclose and overstate controls that exist only on paper. Sources and methods appear at the end.

Terms used in this report

Term	Meaning
Phishing, smishing, vishing	Deceptive emails, text messages and phone calls designed to steal passwords, codes or payments.
Business email compromise (BEC)	Impersonating an executive, supplier or client to get an employee to send money or data.
Ransomware	Malware that locks an organisation's systems and usually steals data, followed by an extortion demand.
Deepfake	AI-generated video, voice or images that imitate a real person.
Open-weight model	An AI model whose underlying files are published. Anyone can download and run it on their own computers, outside the developer's control.
Abliteration	Removing a model's refusal behaviour so it will assist with harmful tasks.
Zero-day / known (n-day) vulnerability	A flaw unknown to the vendor and unpatched / a flaw that is public and patchable but often left unpatched.
Edge device	Internet-facing equipment such as VPN gateways and firewalls. In 2025-26 these were a leading entry point for attackers.
MFA, OTP	Multi-factor authentication; a one-time passcode, often sent by SMS.
SIM swap	Moving a victim's phone number to an attacker's SIM card to intercept SMS codes.
CSIRT, ISAC	A national or sector incident-response team; an information-sharing centre where institutions exchange threat warnings.
Threat-led penetration testing	Authorised simulated attacks that copy real attackers' methods.

1. What changed: from AI-assisted to AI-operated attacks

A short history of 2024-2026

In February 2024, Microsoft and OpenAI reported that state-linked groups from Russia, China, Iran and North Korea were using AI chatbots. They used them for research, scripting, translation and phishing text, and the two companies found "no significant AI-enabled cyberattacks". [1] Two and a half years later, the evidence describes something different.

Date	Event	What AI contributed
Early 2024	An Arup employee in Hong Kong sent HK$200 million (about US$25.6m) after a video call in which the chief financial officer and colleagues were deepfakes [18]	Fake faces and voices; no computer system was hacked
Jul 2025	Malware attributed to Russia's APT28 (LAMEHUG) called Alibaba's open-weight Qwen model to write its commands while running [7, 10]	First malware Google had seen querying an AI model in live operations
Aug 2025	One criminal used Claude Code against at least 17 organisations [2]	Reconnaissance, intrusion, choosing what to steal, and setting ransom demands from victims' own financial data
Aug-Sep 2025	The open-source HexStrike-AI framework was discussed on criminal forums for exploiting newly disclosed Citrix NetScaler flaws within hours [11]	Automating exploitation of freshly published flaws (attacker claims)
Sep-Nov 2025	A group assessed as Chinese state-sponsored (GTG-1002) used Claude Code against about 30 targets, including financial institutions; a small number were breached [3]	An estimated 80-90% of tactical work, with 4-6 human decisions per campaign

Date	Event	What AI contributed
Feb 2026	Fideuram, Intesa Sanpaolo's private bank, lost about EUR95m after a WhatsApp message impersonating the group chief executive and a call using an AI-cloned voice [19]	Voice cloning to authorise payments; about EUR36m remains untraced
Apr 2026	The US Treasury Secretary and Federal Reserve Chair convened bank chief executives over Anthropic's Mythos Preview, a model able to find and exploit unknown flaws [23]	Supervisory alarm about capability, not a documented attack
May 2026	Google reported the first zero-day it assesses was developed with AI: a two-factor-authentication bypass prepared for mass exploitation [8]	Discovering and weaponising a new flaw
May-Jul 2026	A Chinese-speaking actor ran DeepSeek through an open-source agent framework, attempted more than 460 targets and stole data from three NetScaler systems [12]	Autonomous scanning and exploitation
Dec 2025-Aug 2026	Anthropic reported suspected affiliates of the ShinyHunters extortion group using Claude in intrusions whose stolen data included payment-card records and bank account identifiers; one software-supplier breach reached about 200 downstream organisations [5]	Reconnaissance, credential theft, exploitation and extortion
Sep 2026	An operator using GLM-5.2 and DeepSeek V4 models alongside Claude compromised at least 27 companies in five days [13]	About US$25 per target; payment-card skimmers confirmed on 19 sites
Sep-Oct 2026	South Korea: suspected AI-agent-driven attacks hit 16 financial firms, exposing about 100,000 personal records [14-16]	Entry through side portals; a regulator review found 130 of 555 firms deficient
Oct 2026	Straiker reported that a Mexico-based crime group's multi-model framework (CARLIY0S) had targeted more than 400 Latin American financial institutions [17]	Reconnaissance and credential harvesting, mainly using closed US models

Sources as cited. Counts of "targets" include failed attempts and are not counts of breaches.

What AI does at each stage of an attack

Stage	Documented contribution	Evidence
Reconnaissance	Mapping exposed systems and profiling staff at machine speed	GTG-1002 and the DeepSeek agent campaign [3, 12]
Deception	Fluent, personalised lures in any language; cloned voices and faces	In a 101-person study, fully AI-written spear-phishing achieved a 54% click rate, equal to human experts, against 12% for a control group [21]; Fideuram [19]
Exploiting known flaws	Shortening the time from public disclosure to attack	Vulnerability exploitation became the leading initial entry route in 2025 breaches (31%) [22]; NetScaler waves [11, 12]
Finding new flaws	Discovering and weaponising zero-days	First AI-developed zero-day (May 2026) [8]; Mythos Preview [23, 33]
Malware and movement inside networks	Writing and adapting malicious code	560 of 832 accounts Anthropic banned for cyber misuse used AI to write malware [4]
Extortion	Reading stolen financial records to price ransom demands	[2]

What has not changed

The largest losses still come from deceiving people and abusing trusted suppliers:

- North Korea's record US$1.5 billion theft from the Bybit exchange came through a compromised wallet-software supplier. [25]
- The help-desk and phone-impersonation campaigns that hit retailers, insurers and a core-banking vendor in 2025-26 were documented by Google with no recorded AI use. [24]
- In Brazil's instant-payment system, an IT employee at a connectivity provider allegedly sold his login for about US$2,700, and at least R$540 million was diverted. [26] A second provider lost about R$710 million through stolen vendor credentials. [27]

Both OpenAI and Anthropic report that AI so far speeds up existing tradecraft rather than creating new kinds of attack. [3, 6]

Assessment: AI is an accelerant, not a new weapon class. It makes every existing weakness cheaper to find and faster to exploit. The practical consequence for a small country is the loss of protection through obscurity. When scanning and tailored deception cost a few dollars per target, attackers no longer need to choose a market carefully. They can try everyone.

2. Chinese and open-weight models: a real risk, often misdescribed

Why "open-weight" is the issue

Closed models such as Claude, GPT and Gemini run on their developers' servers. Those developers can and do detect misuse: Anthropic detected the GTG-1002 campaign in mid-September 2025, investigated it over about ten days and banned the accounts involved. [3] An open-weight model's files can be downloaded and run on the attacker's own hardware. Its refusals can be removed, and nobody sees what it is asked to do. The UK AI Security Institute (AISI) notes that refusal training is "often easily reversible with access to the weights". [34] Most leading open-weight models in 2026 are Chinese: DeepSeek, Alibaba's Qwen, Moonshot's Kimi and Z.ai's GLM. Western open-weight models such as Llama, Mistral and OpenAI's gpt-oss carry the same structural risk.

Model and developer	Evaluator and date	Finding
DeepSeek R1-0528 (China)	US CAISI (NIST), Sep 2025	Under a common jailbreak, answered 94% of overtly malicious requests, against 8% for US reference models; agents were 12 times more likely to be hijacked [37]
DeepSeek R1 (China)	Cisco and University of Pennsylvania, Jan 2025	Blocked none of 50 harmful test prompts [39]
DeepSeek V4 Pro (China)	CAISI, May 2026	About 8 months behind the US frontier; 32% on a cyber benchmark against 71% for GPT-5.5 [38]
Leading open-weight models	UK AISI, Jul 2026	4-7 months behind closed frontier models on cyber, down from 6-10 months in 2025 [34]
Kimi K3 (China)	UK AISI and CAISI, Jul 2026	Completed a 32-step simulated corporate network attack in 1 of 10 attempts; "capable of autonomously attacking small, weakly defended and vulnerable enterprise systems"; its safeguards did not prevent offensive attempts [35]
GLM-5.3 (China)	CAISI, Sep 2026	"The most cyber-capable open-weight model released to date", about 4 months behind the US frontier [36]
GLM-5.3 (China)	Anthropic, Sep 2026	Refusals fell from 95% to 6% after abliteration, costing an estimated US$1,200-4,400 of computing, with little capability loss. Anthropic is a commercial competitor [40]
Claude Mythos Preview (US, restricted release)	UK AISI, Apr 2026	First model to complete the same 32-step range, in 3 of 10 attempts [33]

Benchmarks and simulated ranges differ; rows are not directly comparable. Capability "lags" are evaluators' estimates.

The economics favour attackers

Cost is where open-weight models change the arithmetic:

- AISI estimated a 100-million-token cyber-range run at about US$46 on GLM-5.2, against about US$85 on Anthropic's Opus 4.5/4.6. AISI also gave a figure of US$1.19 for DeepSeek V4-Pro, but cautioned that it used non-primary providers and that real costs may vary. [34]
- The Bank for International Settlements (BIS) estimates that a full AI attack chain uses about 100 million tokens. That costs US$5,000-10,000 on Mythos Preview but "as little as $50-$100 per attack" on cheaper models. [43]
- In the September 2026 retail campaign, the average cost was US$25.46 per target scanned. [13]
- On criminal forums, mentions of safety-stripped DeepSeek, GLM and Kimi models rose 745% during 2026, with resold access priced at one-sixteenth to one-hundredth of official rates. [42]

Documented use in real attacks

The documented cases include:

- Russia's LAMEHUG called Alibaba's Qwen at runtime. [7, 10]
- A Chinese-speaking actor ran DeepSeek autonomously against hundreds of targets. [12]
- The September retail campaign used GLM and DeepSeek for exploitation. [13]
- Google reports a suspected China-nexus group deploying a local open-weight model inside compromised cloud accounts specifically to avoid commercial monitoring. [9]
- In South Korea, CrowdStrike linked a campaign against financial firms to the Chinese-developed ARTEX agent, with DeepSeek as its main model. CrowdStrike's attribution is moderate-confidence. A Korean security official said the AI "did not act independently without human involvement", and no Korean regulator has named a model. [14, 16]

The limits, stated plainly

The evidence also limits the claims:

- A randomised trial for AISI found no statistically significant uplift from chat-style AI on complete attack chains. RAND's follow-up, however, found that agentic tools solved the same challenges in under an hour each for under US$2. [41]
- Kimi K3 achieved arbitrary code execution on none of 41 exploit samples, against 20 for the strongest US models. [35]
- Every government cyber range so far has lacked active defenders, so success against well-monitored networks is unproven. [33, 44]
- The September retail operator still typed about 1,951 instructions across 260 sessions. [13]
- The Latin American bank-targeting framework relied mainly on closed US models; its Kimi fallback refused offensive requests. [17]
- Several sources have commercial or political interests. The BIS records accusations that Anthropic amplified fear around Mythos. [44]

Defenders' access is not equal

The most capable defensive models are being shared selectively. Anthropic's restricted Glasswing programme expanded in June 2026 to about 150 organisations in more than 15 countries. No Caribbean country or organisation has been named among them. A US export-control directive cut non-US access to Anthropic's most capable models from 12 June to 1 July 2026. [44, 46] Anthropic's broader Cyber Verification Program states no country restriction for its defensive tier (October 2026). [46] The Financial Stability Board (FSB) Chair warned the G20 that differences in cyber capability across jurisdictions "may themselves become a source of vulnerability". [45]

Assessment for T&T: three consequences follow.

1. The safety controls built by US AI companies cannot be relied on to slow attackers.
2. The cost of attempting an attack has fallen to tens of dollars, so small markets are now worth scanning.
3. A four-to-eight-month capability lag is shorter than the time many institutions take to patch internet-facing systems or replace legacy software. It is far shorter than the nine years Trinidad and Tobago has taken without enacting a cybercrime bill.

3. Trinidad and Tobago's track record

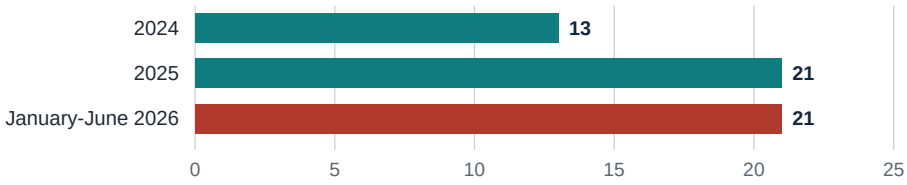
The incidents on the public record

Date	Organisation	What happened
Apr 2022	Massy Stores	Ransomware closed stores and disrupted card payments; the Hive group claimed the attack [47]
Jun-Jul 2023	Office of the Attorney General and Ministry of Legal Affairs	Network intrusion; electronic court filings and government lawyers' email disrupted [48]
Oct 2023	TSTT	RansomEXX ransomware; customer data including identity-document scans leaked. An interim forensic report found the attackers used an administrator's credentials; the final report has not been published [49]
Dec 2023	National Insurance Board (NIBTT)	Ransomware closed all offices from 27 to 29 December [50]
2019-2023	Four insurers	Reported ransomware (2019 and 2023), malware (2021) and a data breach (2022) [63]
Jun 2025	CIBC Caribbean, Trinidad operation	The managing director authorised 19 transfers totalling about $14.8 million (currency not stated) to Hong Kong, Singapore and Bulgaria on WhatsApp and email instructions that appeared to come from the chief executive; about $9.4 million was unaccounted for when reported. The bank's FY2025 annual report confirms a loss from "a fraud incident in Trinidad". No AI use was reported [53, 54]
Jul 2025	Venture Credit Union	Ransomware; members' personal documents leaked. The credit union said core banking data was not compromised; local reporting attributes the attack to the Qilin group [51]
2025-2026	Public figures	Deepfakes of the Prime Minister, the Minister of Finance, the Fair Trading Commission chairman and a former President promoted fraudulent investments [59, 75]
Disclosed Mar 2026	National Quarries Company	Malware destroyed accounting software, delaying audited accounts by years [55]
Jun 2026	Customer of a local commercial bank	Three accounts emptied online over two days: over TT$1 million plus nearly US$100,000, partly recovered. The bank and the method have not been disclosed [56]

What the numbers say, and what they cannot say

Indicator	Value	Caveat
Incidents reported to TT-CSIRT, 2023 to 2024	"More than doubled", driven by phishing and business email compromise	Reported by the Central Bank; TT-CSIRT publishes no counts [62, 77]
FIUTT suspicious transaction reports, Oct 2024-Sep 2025	1,523 reports worth TT$1.254bn, of which TT$762.7m completed; 59% suspected fraud, "majority being online scams"	Suspicions reported, not confirmed losses [58]
TTPS Fraud Squad reports, Jan-Jul 2026	551 reports with reported value of $167.4m, up 227% from $51.2m a year earlier	All fraud types, including $78.9m of fraud against government institutions [57]
Ransomware leak-site listings, T&T	4 (2023), 4 (2024), 5 (2025), 0 (Jan-Jun 2026)	Victims who pay are often not listed; the consultant estimates actual breaches at about twice the listings [52]
Ransomware leak-site listings, Caribbean	13 (2024), 21 (2025), 21 (Jan-Jun 2026)	Finance and investment tied for most-targeted sector in early 2026 [52]

Caribbean ransomware leak-site listings | number of listed victims (CFSI)



The official data are inconsistent:

- TT-CSIRT's public statistics page, updated in July 2026, shows no data for 2019-2026. [77]
- At an October 2025 meeting, the Central Bank Governor cited about $3.3 million lost to online fraud over a year. [61] In the first seven months of 2025 alone, police fraud reports totalled $51.2 million. [57]
- The IMF cited 147 incidents for 2019-2022 [81], while the Central Bank cited 205 successful attacks for 2019-2023. [63]

A country that cannot count its cyber incidents cannot tell whether its defences are working. That is a readiness failure in itself.

Reading the record

Three patterns stand out.

- **Entry has mostly come through people and credentials.** At TSTT it was an administrator's account. At CIBC it was impersonation of the chief executive. Police now warn about unexpected one-time-passcode prompts leading to account hijacking. [57]
- **The damage has concentrated on the periphery.** Telecoms, government agencies, an insurer group, a credit union and retailers have been hit, not the core systems of commercial banks. That is consistent with attackers taking the easiest route. It is not evidence that banks are hardened.
- **The CIBC case is the template AI makes cheaper.** Arup and Fideuram show the same playbook with a cloned voice or a fake video call replacing a WhatsApp message. [18, 19, 53]

Geopolitical exposure has also risen. Trinidad and Tobago backed the 2025 US naval campaign. Venezuela declared the Prime Minister persona non grata in October 2025, and US forces captured Nicolás Maduro on 3 January 2026. [31, 32] The documented cyber activity in that crisis was aimed at Venezuela. This research found no confirmed spillover attacks, and no documented hacktivist campaign, against T&T or Caribbean financial institutions. The region is nonetheless busy: Latin America was the most-attacked region in Check Point's telemetry in September 2026. SIM-swap services are openly advertised to criminals, and AI is producing native-language Spanish and Portuguese phishing. [29, 30]

4. The rulebook: Central Bank regulation and supervision

The Central Bank of Trinidad and Tobago (CBTT) has built the only working cyber rulebook in the financial sector. Measured against the "second generation" of bank cyber regulation that was common by 2023, it is respectable. [96] Measured against what changed in 2026, it has not moved.

Instrument	What it does	Assessment
Cybersecurity Best Practices Guideline (Sep 2023)	20 requirements across governance, risk management, training, continuity, testing and incident management, with annual self-assessments signed by the chief executive [64]	Principles-based. Customer multi-factor authentication, patch management and information sharing sit in a section of practices that are "recommended but which are not essential to comply". Patches are due "within a timeframe that is commensurate with the criticality", with no deadline. The guideline does not mention AI. Breaching a guideline is not an offence, but the CBTT can issue compliance directions [64, 72]
Mandatory incident reporting (circular dated 5 Feb 2025)	Initial notice within 24 hours, full report within 72 hours, regular updates and a lessons-learned report. Covers banks, insurers, payment operators and e-money issuers, and explicitly includes social engineering that leads to unauthorised wire transfers [65]	Meets common international timing: New York and Jamaica require 72 hours [88, 89]. Slower than Barbados, which requires an initial report within 4 hours of classifying a major incident [87]. Posted publicly about five months after issue
Annual self-assessment with action plans and independent review [65]	Annual tracking of gaps	Aggregate results have never been published
Cybersecurity supervision framework	Policies for off-site monitoring and on-site examinations [67]	Described as "developed" but not published. One joint IT and cyber on-site examination, of a large bank, was conducted in FY2024/25 [67]
Payment system operator licensing (effective 29 Sep 2026)	Applies international payment-infrastructure standards, including cyber resilience guidance and a 2-hour recovery target [70]	Strong on paper. Written for initial licensing, with no stated transition for incumbent operators. Significant retail systems need meet critical standards only "partially" [70]
Strategic Plan 2026/27-2030/31 (Oct 2026)	Names "the AI-cybersecurity nexus" and third-party technology concentration as emerging risks [68]	None of its 23 projects is dedicated to cyber resilience; climate risk receives its own supervisory framework project [68]

Evidence from the Central Bank's own reviews

The CBTT's 2022 thematic review covered 7 of the 8 commercial banks:

- Three had no clearly documented, board-approved information-security strategy.
- There was "no formal evidence of threat information sharing among the commercial banks".
- Three banks used the same managed security provider, a concentration risk.
- Foreign-owned banks' cybersecurity was largely driven by their parent groups.

The review relied on self-assessments and interviews; it did not test whether controls worked. [66] The latest Financial Stability Report, covering 2024, rates sector cyber risk "elevated" and cites a shortage of skilled cyber professionals. [62] Its 2025 successor had not been published by 28 October 2026.

The missing response to frontier AI

After Mythos Preview was announced in April 2026, at least eleven jurisdictions' financial authorities issued statements, letters, inspections or task forces within weeks. [44] Examples:

- The Bank of England, the FCA and HM Treasury asked firms to remediate vulnerabilities "more quickly, more frequently, and at scale". [90]
- New York's financial regulator set out about twenty heightened-threat measures, including phishing-resistant MFA and rapid remediation of internet-facing flaws. [89]
- Canada's OSFI told institutions to accelerate patch management. [94]
- Closer to home, Barbados revised its technology and cyber-risk guideline in March 2026. It now includes an AI section, a 4-hour initial report for major incidents, annual penetration testing and threat-led testing. [87]
- Jamaica launched a sector-wide cyber-intelligence sharing hub in 2025. [88]

A review of the roughly 80 circulars, notices and other documents the CBTT posted between January and October 2026 found nothing on cyber or AI. **On public evidence, Trinidad and Tobago's financial supervisors have not yet responded to the largest change in the cyber threat in a decade.** A private letter to institutions cannot be ruled out. The CBTT posted its February 2025 cyber circulars about five months late.

Outside the Central Bank's reach

- **Credit unions:** an estimated TT$18.5 billion of assets, about 11% of commercial-bank assets. The CBTT's figure has not changed since 2021 because it has no current data. Credit unions are supervised by FIUTT for anti-money-laundering purposes only. They have no prudential or cyber supervisor, and this research found no statutory deposit-insurance scheme for them. [58, 71, 81]
- **Securities firms:** the Securities and Exchange Commission (TTSEC) has issued no cybersecurity guideline for registrants. It treats cyber risk as an emerging risk within supervision. [95]

5. National law and institutions

Area	Status at 28 October 2026	Consequence
Cybercrime law	The Computer Misuse Act 2000 remains the main statute. The Cybercrime Bill 2017 went to a joint select committee and was never enacted. None of the 44 bills in the current Parliament concerns cybercrime [73]	Outdated offences and investigative powers; accession to the main international cybercrime convention (Budapest) is out of reach without new law
Data protection and breach notification	The Data Protection Act 2011 is only partly in force. The obligations on private organisations (Part IV) and most obligations on public bodies (Part III) were never proclaimed. The Act has no breach-notification duty [74]. The FY2027 budget calls modernisation "well advanced" [76]	No general legal duty to tell customers when their data is stolen; only CBTT-regulated institutions must notify their supervisor
National strategy	The National Cyber Security Strategy dates from 2012 [77]	No current national plan for AI-era threats
National incident response team	TT-CSIRT operates on an administrative basis under the Ministry of Homeland Security. It published nothing between 25 September 2025 and 13 March 2026. It issued no Citrix NetScaler advisory after July 2024, despite three exploited waves since. Its statistics page shows no data [77]	Weak early warning for exactly the kind of fast-exploited flaw AI agents use
Cyber agency	The Cyber Security Agency Bill (2015) was never passed [73, 77]	No statutory coordinator
AI and cyber coordination	Cabinet approved an inter-ministerial steering committee on cybersecurity and AI on 11 September 2025 and endorsed a five-year "national cybersecurity and AI safety framework" [75]	No report or framework text had been published by October 2026
Fiscal support	The cybersecurity investment tax allowance (up to TT$500,000) appears to have lapsed on 31 December 2025. The FY2027 budget mentions cybersecurity only for virtual-asset licensing [76]	Weaker incentive to invest in security
Telecoms	The regulator TATT's January 2026 framework requires 24-hour incident notice. It explicitly allows SMS one-time codes and contains no SIM-swap control [80]	Banks' most common second factor rests on an unregulated weak point

International indices agree:

- The ITU's Global Cybersecurity Index 2024 places Trinidad and Tobago in Tier 3, "Establishing", at about 56 out of 100. It is weakest on legal measures (8.9 of 20) and technical measures (7.0 of 20). [78]
- The National Cyber Security Index scores the country 35.8 and ranks it 110th. It scores zero on incident-reporting obligations, critical-infrastructure protection and cybercrime law. [79]
- A 2025 IDB-OAS review ranked Trinidad and Tobago among the three most mature Caribbean states, but no Caribbean country reached the top stage in any dimension. [93]

There has been some activity:

- a TT-CSIRT agreement with TATT on telecom threat sharing (March 2026);
- a letter of intent with a regional cyber competence centre (July 2026);
- engagement with CARICOM IMPACS;
- foundational training for 40 young people. [77]

The Bankers Association (BATT) used its budget response to urge full proclamation of the data-protection and electronic-transactions laws. [98] **Still, the national legal framework has barely moved since 2017.**

6. What institutions and shared infrastructure show in practice

A large, concentrated, well-capitalised system

- **Size:** domestic financial-sector assets were TT$374.0 billion at end-2024. Banks, insurers and pension funds held 77.5% of that, equal to 166.2% of GDP. [62]
- **Banks:** eight commercial banks held TT$166.6 billion at end-2025. [71] Two are designated domestically systemically important. [62]
- **Capital:** banks are well capitalised, with a capital adequacy ratio of 18.2% in December 2024. [62]
- **Loss-absorbing capacity:** a single fraud loss of a few million dollars does not threaten solvency. **The cyber risk to this system is not insolvency. It is outages, stolen data, eroded trust and losses that fall on customers and smaller institutions.**

Customer protection: what banks publicly describe

Institution	Publicly described controls	Gap against leading practice
Republic Bank	Second factor by SMS code, app code or app approval; passwords of 8-12 characters with no special characters allowed; retail third-party transfers capped at TT$50,000; beneficiaries must be pre-registered	SMS remains selectable; no confirmation of payee or new-payee delay described
Scotiabank T&T	Biometric sign-in, hardware and software tokens, two-step codes; reimbursement guarantee if customers meet their security obligations	Guarantee is conditional
CIBC Caribbean	One-time code needed to add a payee; after the 2025 fraud, expanded MFA and "zero-trust" defences [54]	No account-name confirmation described
ANSA Bank	A code sent to the customer's mobile phone for every online transaction; 15-minute biometric sign-up	Relies on phone-delivered codes
First Citizens, RBC Royal Bank	Not verified: their websites blocked automated review	Not assessed

Source: banks' public security pages and annual reports [54, 83]. Public pages do not prove the absence of internal fraud controls.

New York's regulator advises firms to avoid SMS, voice or video as authentication factors because of deepfakes and SIM swapping. [89] US cyber authorities have told users not to rely on SMS as a second factor after Chinese state actors penetrated telecom networks. [28] In Trinidad and Tobago, the mobile market is a near-duopoly with a concentration index of 5,014, and 79% of lines are prepaid. [80] The 2023 TSTT leak exposed identity scans and phone numbers [49], exactly the raw material for SIM-swap fraud. No public data exist on SIM-swap controls at either operator.

Boards, skills and insiders

Governance evidence is thin:

- First Citizens' 2025 board skills matrix rates none of nine directors "very skilled" in IT or cybersecurity: four are rated moderately skilled and five as having no skill. [84]
- In a survey of 105 Caribbean directors, only 16% said their boards strongly understood cybersecurity's strategic importance, and 31% of boards never received cyber reports. [82]

Insider risk also matters, and AI does not remove it. In November 2025 a court found a former ANSA Bank officer liable for a scheme of sham vehicle loans worth about TT$30 million and said the bank should have had better

internal systems. [60]

Information sharing

BATT has security and cybersecurity committees with one representative per bank. [85] This research found no public evidence of a formal threat-intelligence platform, and the CBTT's own guideline only encourages an "informal" group. [64, 66] Jamaica now runs a sector-wide sharing hub. Its central bank partly attributes an 18% fall in reported bank fraud in 2025 to information sharing and stronger rules. [88]

Shared infrastructure: the system's single points of failure

Infolink Services, owned by First Citizens, RBC, Republic Bank and Scotiabank, runs three of the four interbank payment systems:

- the LINX debit network, switching more than 39 million transactions a year;
- the automated clearing house (ACH);
- electronic cheque clearing. [70]

The ACH processed 20.4 million transactions worth TT$182.7 billion in 2024, roughly **TT$730 million per business day**. [62] Infolink has published no incident disclosures and no public assessment against international payment-infrastructure standards. [70]

On 22 October 2026, Jamaica's equivalent operator, JETS, disclosed a breach of its administrative systems that may have exposed card numbers and payee names. Its payment networks kept running. [88] It is the closest regional warning yet.

Other concentrations:

- the managed security provider shared by three banks in 2022 [66];
- reliance on a few cloud and technology vendors, which the CBTT itself flags [62];
- a pending change of ownership at CIBC Caribbean, which Butterfield agreed in May 2026 to acquire, with completion expected in the first half of 2027. [86] Integration periods often bring system migrations and new access rights. That makes them periods of elevated risk, an analytical judgment rather than a finding about this transaction.

Buffers that help

Several features limit the damage an attack can do:

- Banks have completed migration to chip cards. [62]
- Cash remains widely used, with TT$36.6 billion withdrawn from ATMs in 2024. [62]
- E-money is still small, at TT$0.12 billion of transactions in 2024. [62]

These limit the reach of an attack on digital payment channels. Foreign exchange scarcity cuts the other way. The CBTT sold US$400 million to dealers in January-April 2026, and reserves stood at 5.8 months of imports in mid-2026. [71] Security tools, managed services and specialist staff are largely priced in US dollars. Limited foreign exchange makes defences harder to buy.

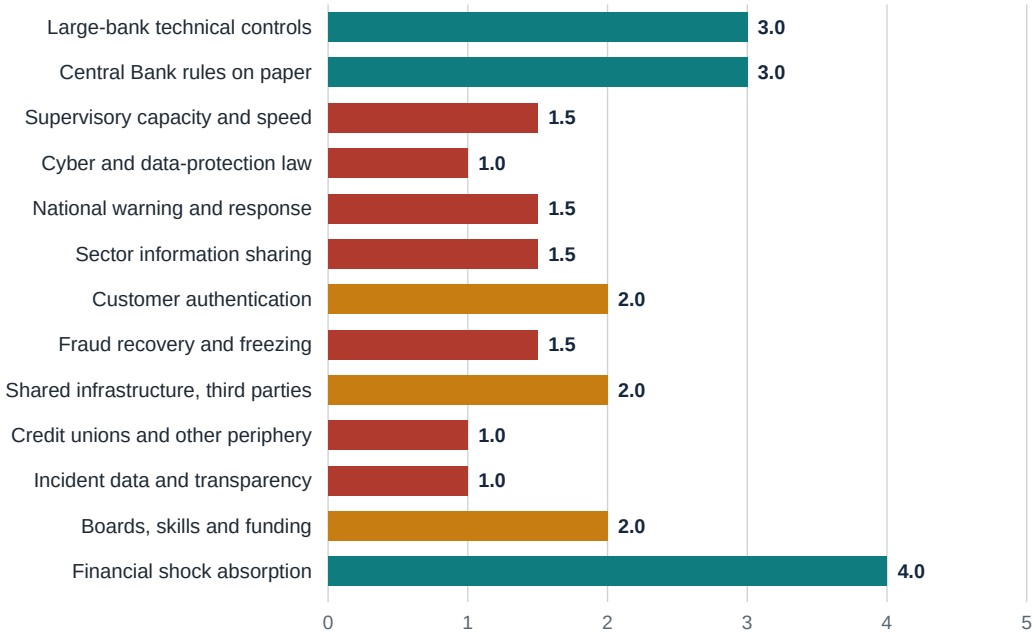
7. Readiness scorecard

Each domain is rated from 1 to 5 against the international practice described in this report: [43-45, 87-91]

- **1:** absent, or a major gap.
- **2:** early or partial.
- **3:** broadly meets a 2023-era baseline.
- **4:** largely meets current practice.
- **5:** comparable with leading jurisdictions.

The ratings are analytical judgments from public evidence and are not weighted.

Readiness scorecard | 1 = absent or major gap, 3 = 2023-era baseline, 5 = leading practice



Domain	Rating	Basis
Technical controls at the largest banks	3.0	International frameworks, 24x7 monitoring and parent-group programmes reported; SMS codes and limited payee verification persist [66, 83]
Central Bank rules on paper	3.0	24/72-hour reporting, self-assessment and testing expectations; key controls only "recommended"; no AI content [64, 65]
Supervisory capacity and speed	1.5	One joint cyber examination in a year; unpublished framework; no public response to frontier AI [67, 68]
National cyber and data-protection law	1.0	Cybercrime bill lapsed; data-protection obligations unproclaimed; no breach notification law [73, 74]
National warning and incident response	1.5	Administrative CSIRT with publication gaps and no statistics [77]
Sector information sharing	1.5	Industry committees but no formal platform [64, 66, 85]
Customer authentication and payment controls	2.0	Multi-factor login is common, but SMS-based; no confirmation of payee in public descriptions [83]
Fraud recovery and cross-border freezing	1.5	Ad hoc; a business chamber called for a rapid-freeze protocol in 2026 [56, 69]
Shared infrastructure and third parties	2.0	New payment licensing standards; incumbent switch's resilience unpublished; concentration noted [66, 70]

Domain	Rating	Basis
Credit unions, insurers, securities and fintech periphery	1.0	No credit-union prudential or cyber supervisor; no securities cyber guideline; ransomware history [51, 58, 63, 95]
Incident data and transparency	1.0	Contradictory figures; no public CSIRT data; no aggregate supervisory data [57, 61, 77]
Boards, skills and funding	2.0	Board skill gaps; staff shortages; lapsed tax allowance; foreign-exchange constraints [62, 76, 82, 84]
Financial shock absorption	4.0	Strong capital, chip cards and a cash fallback [62]
Unweighted average	**1.9**	**Not ready for a determined AI-assisted group; partly ready for routine crime**

The pattern is clear. Defences are strongest where foreign parents and capital rules do the work, and weakest wherever national government action is required.

8. How an AI-armed group would most likely attack, and what would happen

The question is not whether a group could break into Trinidad and Tobago's best-defended bank core. It is which route a rational attacker would choose, and how the system would respond. The table describes likely routes at a strategic level only.

Attack route	Why it fits T&T	Likelihood (12 months)	Impact	Readiness
Impersonated or deepfaked executive orders urgent payments	Already happened at CIBC (2025); deepfakes of ministers are common; Fideuram shows the AI version	High	Millions of dollars per case; reputational damage	Low to medium: depends on each bank's call-back rules; no sector standard
AI-written phishing, texts and calls lead to account takeover via stolen codes or SIM swaps	Phishing drove the 2024 doubling in incidents; SMS codes are widespread; TSTT leak data exist	High	Many individual losses, concentrated on elderly customers; erosion of trust	Low
Rapid exploitation of an unpatched internet-facing system at a credit union, insurer, broker or vendor, followed by ransomware or extortion	Venture Credit Union and insurers already hit; the Korean "side-door" pattern; national advisory gaps	High	Outages lasting days to weeks; data leaks	Low
Deepfake or synthetic identities used to open accounts for laundering	FIUTT reports a rise in onboarding fraud; digital account opening is spreading [58]	Medium to high	Laundering; damage to international standing	Low: FIUTT's advisory does not address liveness or deepfake detection
Compromise of a shared provider such as a payment switch, core vendor, security provider or telecom	Infolink concentration; the JETS breach; three banks sharing a security provider	Low to medium	Potentially system-wide	Unknown; low on public evidence
AI-assisted intrusion into a large bank's core network	GTG-1002 targeted financial institutions; AI lowers the cost of trying	Low to medium	High	Medium
Politically motivated disruption linked to regional tensions	Venezuela-related tensions since 2025	Low	Medium to high	Low to medium

Likelihood and impact are analytical judgments, not probabilities. Readiness reflects public evidence only.

The most likely damage is not a single dramatic heist. It is a rising volume of impersonation fraud, account takeovers and ransomware at the periphery, each individually survivable. Together they drain customers, burden police and erode confidence in digital banking just as the CBTT plans an instant-payment system and a fully digital payments system by 2035. [70]

The tail risk is an outage at shared infrastructure. A multi-day failure of the ACH or the LINX network would interrupt salaries, bill payments and card transactions across all participating banks. The cash fallback would limit, but not eliminate, the harm. Abroad, ransomware took a US$9 billion California credit union's online services down for about two weeks and capped its ATM withdrawals at US$500. [97] A similar event at a large local credit union or insurer is plausible.

9. What would make Trinidad and Tobago ready

Most of the required measures are rules and coordination, not expensive technology. The binding constraints are political priority, legislative time and specialist staff.

Within three months: no new legislation needed

Action	Responsible	Why
Issue a frontier-AI supervisory letter requiring accelerated patching of internet-facing systems, inventories of exposed devices, tested backups and board briefings	CBTT, TTSEC	At least eleven jurisdictions did so in 2026 at little cost [44, 89, 90]
Set a sector standard for payment instructions: independent call-back verification for urgent, executive or new-beneficiary payments above a threshold; no approval on WhatsApp or email alone	CBTT with BATT	Directly targets the CIBC and Fideuram pattern [19, 53, 92]
Create a 24/7 rapid fraud-freeze protocol among banks, police and FIUTT, including templates for cross-border recall requests	CBTT, BATT, TTPS, FIUTT	Singapore and Hong Kong police recovered essentially all of a US$499,000 deepfake-induced transfer through fast cross-border cooperation [20]; a local business chamber has asked for exactly this [56]
Publish aggregate incident and fraud statistics	CBTT, TT-CSIRT, TTPS	Turns anecdotes into evidence and lets progress be measured

Within twelve months

- **Law:** enact a modern cybercrime law and proclaim the Data Protection Act with mandatory breach notification. Give TT-CSIRT a statutory mandate, staff and budget, including national exposure feeds so owners of vulnerable systems are warned within hours.
- **Customer authentication:** require phishing-resistant MFA for staff privileged and remote access. Phase out SMS codes for high-risk customer actions such as adding a payee, raising limits or changing devices. Build confirmation of payee into the planned instant-payment system before launch, not after.
- **Patching:** set deadlines for actively exploited, internet-facing vulnerabilities measured in days rather than "commensurate" timeframes.
- **Sharing:** build a sector threat-sharing hub on Jamaica's model, covering banks, insurers, credit unions, Infolink and the telecom operators. [88]
- **Testing:** require threat-led penetration testing for the systemically important banks and Infolink. Apply the new payment-infrastructure cyber standards to incumbent operators.
- **Periphery:** bring credit unions under prudential and cyber supervision. Encourage pooled security monitoring for small credit unions and insurers that cannot afford their own.
- **Telecoms:** have TATT require SIM-swap controls and a way for banks to check whether a SIM was recently changed before trusting an SMS code.
- **Defensive AI:** seek access to AI developers' defensive programmes, individually or through regional bodies, and use AI for fraud detection and patch prioritisation.
- **Exercises:** run a sector-wide exercise that combines ransomware at a shared provider with deepfake payment fraud, and publish the lessons.

10. What to monitor, and the final judgment

Indicator	Why it changes the assessment
A CBTT or TTSEC communication on frontier AI	The clearest signal that supervisors have registered the 2026 shift
Publication of the 2025 Financial Stability Report with incident counts	Tests whether the Central Bank will publish evidence rather than adjectives
A cybercrime bill tabled; Data Protection Act proclaimed with breach notification	Determines whether the national framework moves at all
TT-CSIRT statistics and timely advisories on exploited edge devices	Measures national early warning
Credit-union supervisory legislation	Closes the largest unsupervised segment
Outcome of Jamaica's JETS investigation, due 31 October 2026	Shows how a regional payment switch was entered and what Infolink should check
Bank authentication changes: SMS phase-out, confirmation of payee	Shows whether customer-facing defences are adapting
Police fraud values and ransomware listings	Shows whether the attack volume is rising or being contained
Any attributed AI-enabled incident in the Caribbean	Converts a projected threat into a demonstrated one

Final judgment

Trinidad and Tobago's financial system is not ready for a hacker group equipped with current AI models, including freely available Chinese open-weight models. The reason is not a lack of capital or the absence of any rules. The largest banks are well capitalised, partly protected by international parent groups, and subject to a Central Bank guideline and a 24/72-hour incident-reporting rule that compare reasonably with 2023 international practice.

The weakness is the system around them:

- a cybercrime law from 2000 and a data-protection law left mostly unproclaimed for fifteen years;
- a national response team that publishes no statistics;
- a supervisor with no public response to frontier AI;
- no formal information sharing;
- a large credit-union sector outside prudential and cyber supervision;
- customer security that still leans on SMS codes.

AI multiplies exactly these weaknesses. It makes impersonation more convincing, scanning cheaper and exploitation faster. Open-weight models remove the last external brake.

The evidence does **not** show that a successful AI-driven attack on a local bank has occurred, that open-weight models outperform US models, or that a systemic cyber crisis is imminent. Losses to date have been material but not systemic, and strong capital and a cash fallback limit the damage to the financial system itself.

The appropriate conclusion is a large and widening readiness gap. The cheapest fixes are regulatory and organisational, and could begin within weeks. Every month without them leaves attackers' falling costs to meet unchanged defences.

Sources, methods and verification

Evidence boundaries

The report uses public research, official statistics, regulator and parliamentary documents, company disclosures, and threat reports from AI developers and security firms. Research was completed on 28 October 2026. No institution was contacted, tested or given an opportunity to comment, and no confidential supervisory information was available. Absence of a public incident does not mean absence of an incident: ransomware victims who pay are often not listed, and there is no general breach-notification duty.

Several source types have interests to weigh:

- AI developers' threat reports (Anthropic, OpenAI, Google) describe misuse of their own products, and the developers compete commercially with Chinese labs.
- Security vendors sell defensive products.
- Government evaluators frame some findings in terms of US-China competition.
- Criminal-market prices and victim counts are often self-reported by attackers.

Figures reported in different currencies or without a stated currency are given as published. Local police and court figures reported in dollars are taken to be Trinidad and Tobago dollars, following local convention. The CIBC loss is reported without a currency. Where sources conflicted, the report uses the primary source and notes the conflict.

Calculation conventions

Calculation	Definition
ACH value per business day	TT$182.7bn / 250 business days = approximately TT$730m. The business-day count is an assumption.
Credit-union share	TT$18.5bn estimated credit-union assets / TT$166.6bn commercial-bank assets = approximately 11%. Dates differ slightly.
Global Cybersecurity Index total	Sum of five ITU pillar scores: 8.88 + 6.98 + 16.21 + 13.03 + 11.13 = 56.23.
Korean deficiency share	130 / 555 firms = 23.4%.
Fraud Squad change	$167.37m / $51.15m - 1 = +227%.
Scorecard average	Unweighted mean of 13 domain ratings = 25 / 13 = 1.9.

Scorecard method

Domains were chosen to cover the controls that international authorities emphasised in 2026: governance, patching speed, authentication, response and recovery, third-party concentration, information sharing and incident reporting. Ratings compare public evidence on Trinidad and Tobago with the practices in the cited international and regional sources. A different weighting, or confidential evidence, could change individual ratings. It is unlikely to change the overall conclusion, which rests on documented gaps in law, data and supervisory response.

References: AI-enabled attacks and the global threat

[1] Microsoft Threat Intelligence and OpenAI (14 February 2024), state actors' use of large language models. Infosecurity Magazine coverage.

[2] Anthropic (27 August 2025), *Detecting and countering misuse of AI*. Report.

[3] Anthropic (13 November 2025), *Disrupting the first reported AI-orchestrated cyber espionage campaign*. Report.

[4] Anthropic (3 June 2026), *What we learned mapping a year's worth of AI-enabled cyber threats*. Report.

[5] Anthropic (10 September 2026), *Threat intelligence report: September 2026*. Report.

[6] OpenAI (October 2025), *Disrupting malicious uses of AI*. Report.

[7] Google Threat Intelligence Group (5 November 2025), *Advances in threat actor usage of AI tools*. Report.

[8] Google Threat Intelligence Group (May 2026), *Adversaries leverage AI for vulnerability exploitation, augmented operations, and initial access*. Report.

[9] Google Threat Intelligence Group (8 September 2026), *From prompting to autonomy*. Report.

[10] BleepingComputer (July 2025), CERT-UA's disclosure of LAMEHUG malware using Qwen. Article.

[11] Check Point (2 September 2025), *HexStrike-AI: when LLMs meet zero-day exploitation*. Report.

[12] Palo Alto Networks Unit 42 (30 July 2026), *Chinese-speaking threat actor harnesses AI models for autonomous cyberattacks*. Report.

[13] Gambit Security (22 September 2026), autonomous AI agents compromising online retailers for about US$25 per target. Interim vendor report. Report.

[14] CrowdStrike (7 October 2026), *Unknown threat actor uses AI-driven ARTEX to target South Korean finance*. Moderate-confidence attribution. Report.

[15] Korea Times (14 October 2026), *AI-driven cyberattacks hit 16 financial firms, expose 100,000 records*. Article.

[16] American Banker (October 2026), *AI-linked hacks hit Korean banks through loan-agent sites*. Article.

[17] Straiker (21 October 2026), *Inside CARLIY0S*. Counts targets, not compromises. Report.

[18] CNN (16 May 2024), Arup deepfake loss in Hong Kong. Article.

[19] Sky TG24 (25 September 2026) and Private Banker International (28 September 2026), Fideuram voice-clone fraud. Details from unnamed sources. Sky TG24 · Private Banker International via Yahoo Finance.

[20] Singapore Police Force (7 April 2025), recovery of funds from a deepfake video-call scam with Hong Kong police. Release.

[21] Heiding, F., Schneier, B. et al., *Evaluating large language models' ability to automate spear phishing*. Controlled study, 101 participants. Paper page.

[22] Verizon (19 May 2026), *2026 Data Breach Investigations Report*. Release.

[23] Sullivan & Cromwell (April 2026), Treasury Secretary and Federal Reserve Chair warn bank CEOs about Mythos cyber risks. Memo.

[24] Google Threat Intelligence Group (June 2025, updated), *The cost of a call: from voice phishing to data extortion*. Report.

[25] FBI (26 February 2025), *North Korea responsible for US$1.5 billion Bybit hack*. Public service announcement.

[26] The Record (July 2025), Brazil police arrest IT worker over C&M Software theft. Article.

[27] EVERTEC (September 2025), Form 8-K on the Sinqia incident. Filing.

[28] CISA and partners (27 August 2025), advisory AA25-239A on Chinese state-sponsored network compromise; CISA (December 2024) mobile communications guidance. Advisory · Mobile guidance.

[29] Recorded Future (2 April 2026), *Latin America and the Caribbean cybercrime landscape*. Report.

[30] Check Point (October 2026), *September 2026 cyber threat landscape*. Vendor telemetry. Report.

[31] Al Jazeera (28 October 2025), Venezuela declares Trinidad and Tobago's prime minister persona non grata. Article.

[32] SecurityWeek (January 2026), reports on cyber operations' role in the Maduro capture. Article.

References: AI model capability and policy

[33] UK AI Security Institute (13 April 2026), *Our evaluation of Claude Mythos Preview's cyber capabilities*. Blog.

[34] UK AI Security Institute (17 July 2026), *How far behind the frontier are leading open weight models on cyber?* Blog.

[35] UK AISI and US CAISI (23 July 2026), *Preliminary assessment of Kimi K3's cyber capabilities*. Assessment.

[36] NIST CAISI (17 September 2026), *Assessment of Z.ai's GLM-5.3 cyber capabilities*. Assessment.

[37] NIST CAISI (30 September 2025), *Evaluation of DeepSeek AI models finds shortcomings and risks*. Release.

[38] NIST CAISI (1 May 2026), *Evaluation of DeepSeek V4 Pro*. Release.

[39] Cisco (31 January 2025), *Evaluating security risk in DeepSeek and other frontier reasoning models*. Blog.

[40] Anthropic (29 September 2026), *GLM-5.3 and the spread of advanced cyber capabilities*. Commercial competitor's assessment. Research.

[41] RAND (2026), human uplift study of frontier AI for offensive cyber operations, and follow-up on AI agents. Report.

[42] Flare (20 October 2026), *AI models are fueling a new wave of cybercrime: a quantitative analysis*. Report.

[43] Bank for International Settlements (20 July 2026), *A Mythos moment? Frontier AI and cyber risk*, BIS Bulletin No 129. Bulletin.

[44] BIS Financial Stability Institute (September 2026), *When machines attack: frontier AI cyber threats and policy responses in the financial sector*, Occasional Paper No 28. Paper.

[45] Financial Stability Board (31 August 2026), Chair's letter to G20 Finance Ministers and Central Bank Governors on frontier AI. Letter.

[46] Anthropic (2 June and 6 October 2026), *Expanding Project Glasswing* and *Cyber Verification Program*. Glasswing expansion · Cyber Verification Program.

References: Trinidad and Tobago incidents and fraud

[47] The Record (May 2022), *Trinidad's largest supermarket chain crippled by cyberattack*; TechNewsTT (September 2022) on the Hive group's claim. The Record · TechNewsTT.

[48] The Record (July 2023), *Trinidad and Tobago hit with cyberattack*. Article.

[49] Trinidad Express (February 2024), *Report: hackers accessed TSTT using admin's credentials*; TSTT update (3 November 2023). Express · TSTT.

[50] The Record (December 2023), *Trinidad and Tobago social security agency hit with post-Christmas ransomware attack*. Article.

[51] TechNewsTT (August 2025), *Venture Credit Union announces recovery from ransomware attack*. Article.

[52] Computer Forensics and Security Institute (CFSI), Caribbean ransomware reports for 2024, 2025 and January-June 2026; TechNewsTT on 2023 data. Leak-site listings, anonymised; the author's firm sells security services. 2024 · 2025 · H1 2026 · 2023.

[53] Trinidad Guardian (July 2025), *Online scammers steal millions from CIBC T&T*. Article.

[54] CIBC Caribbean Bank (December 2025), *Annual Report 2025*: Chair's message and cyber disclosures. Annual report.

[55] Trinidad Guardian (March 2026), *Malware attack delays National Quarry financials*. Article.

[56] Trinidad Express (16-17 July 2026), *Businessman questions bank after $1m cyber theft*. Victim's account. Article.

[57] Trinidad Express (26 August 2026), *Fraud Squad gets fewer reports but losses rise 227%*. Article.

[58] FIUTT (March 2026), *Annual Report 2025*; Advisory ADV/003/2025 on onboarding fraud (8 December 2025). Annual report · Advisory.

[59] TTSEC (April 2026) and Ministry of Finance (15 June 2026), public advisories on deepfake videos. TTSEC · Ministry of Finance.

[60] Trinidad Express (November 2025), *$30M scam: inside the collusion between bank staff and car dealers*. Article.

[61] Trinidad Guardian (October 2025), *Rising online fraud worries Central Bank*. Article.

References: Trinidad and Tobago regulation, law and structure

[62] CBTT (September 2025), *Financial Stability Report 2024*. Report.

[63] CBTT (September 2024), *Financial Stability Report 2023*. Report.

[64] CBTT (September 2023), *Cybersecurity Best Practices Guideline for Financial Institutions*, especially Section 3 and Appendix II. Guideline.

[65] CBTT circulars CB-OIFI-399/2025, *Mandatory cybersecurity incident reporting* (5 February 2025), and CB-OIFI-450/2025 on annual self-assessments (11 February 2025). Incident reporting · Self-assessment.

[66] CBTT (August 2022), *Report on the thematic review of commercial banks' cybersecurity risk management practices*. Report.

[67] CBTT (May 2026), *Annual Report 2025*; risk-based supervision framework effective 1 October 2025. Annual report · Framework.

[68] CBTT (October 2026), *Strategic Plan 2026/27-2030/31: Insight to Impact*. Plan.

[69] CBTT (28 October 2025), *Central Bank leads collaborative efforts to tackle online banking fraud*. Release.

[70] CBTT, *Licensing procedures for payment system operators* (effective 29 September 2026), *Payment system landscape* and *Payment services* registers; Infolink Services, *About us*; CBTT working paper WP04/2026 on instant payments. Licensing · Landscape · Payment services · Infolink · WP04/2026.

[71] CBTT, *Economic DataPack* (September 2026) and *Monetary Policy Report* (May 2026). DataPack · MPR.

[72] *Financial Institutions Act*, Chap. 79:09, sections 10, 12 and 86. Consolidated text.

[73] Parliament of Trinidad and Tobago, *The Cybercrime Bill, 2017* and bills of the 13th Parliament. Cybercrime Bill · Bills list.

[74] *Data Protection Act*, Chap. 22:04, proclamation status; Senate Hansard (21 April 2026). Legislation library · Hansard.

[75] Senate Hansard (29 October 2025), motion on the growing threat of deepfake technology. Hansard.

[76] Ministry of Finance, *Budget Statement 2026* (13 October 2025) and *Budget Statement 2027* (12 October 2026); *Finance Act 2026*. Budget 2026 · Budget 2027 · Finance Act 2026.

[77] TT-CSIRT, *National cyber security documents*, *Statistics*, and posts and advisories feed. Documents · Statistics · Regional collaboration.

[78] ITU (September 2024), *Global Cybersecurity Index 2024*, country profile. Report.

[79] e-Governance Academy, *National Cyber Security Index: Trinidad and Tobago* (updated April 2025). Index.

[80] TATT (30 January 2026), *Cybersecurity framework for public telecommunications networks*; *Annual market report 2025*. Framework · Market report.

[81] IMF (June 2024), *Trinidad and Tobago: 2024 Article IV Consultation*. Report.

[82] Arthur Lok Jack Global School of Business (January 2025), *Assessing the readiness of Caribbean boards for effective cybersecurity oversight*. Caribbean-wide, all sectors. Study.

[83] Banks' customer security pages and disclosures, viewed October 2026: Republic Bank, Scotiabank Trinidad and Tobago, CIBC Caribbean and ANSA Bank; Republic Financial Holdings *Annual Report 2025*. Republic · Scotiabank · CIBC Caribbean · ANSA Bank · RFHL.

[84] First Citizens Group Financial Holdings (January 2026), *Annual Report 2025*, Appendix 1 skills matrix. Annual report.

[85] Bankers Association of Trinidad and Tobago, *About*. Page.

[86] CIBC Caribbean Bank (28 May 2026), notice of material change on the Butterfield transaction. Notice.

References: international and regional benchmarks

[87] Central Bank of Barbados (revised 31 March 2026), *Technology and cyber risk management guideline*. Guideline.

[88] Bank of Jamaica, *Standard of sound practice on the management of cyber risks* (2024); *Financial Stability Report 2025*; statement on the cyber incident at JETS Limited (23 October 2026). Standard · FSR 2025 · JETS statement.

[89] New York Department of Financial Services: industry letters of 21 May 2026 on frontier AI and on heightened-threat measures; 16 October 2024 letter on AI cyber risks; 23 NYCRR Part 500. Frontier AI · Heightened-threat measures · AI risks 2024 · Part 500.

[90] Bank of England, FCA and HM Treasury (15 May 2026), *Joint statement on frontier AI models and cyber resilience*. Statement.

[91] IMF (April 2024), *Global Financial Stability Report*, Chapter 3, *Cyber risk: a growing concern for macrofinancial stability*. Chapter.

[92] FS-ISAC (October 2024), *Deepfakes in the financial sector: understanding the threats, managing the risks*. Paper.

[93] ICT Pulse (January 2026), summary of the 2025 IDB-OAS cybersecurity maturity report for the Caribbean. Summary.

[94] OSFI (April 2026, modified July 2026), *Technology risk bulletin: frontier artificial intelligence*. Bulletin.

[95] TTSEC (7 July 2023), circular on the enhanced risk-based supervision framework. Circular.

[96] BIS Financial Stability Institute (June 2023), *Banks' cyber security: a second generation of regulatory approaches*, FSI Insights No 50. Paper.

[97] The Record (2024), Patelco Credit Union ransomware and data breach. Article.

[98] Trinidad Express (13 October 2026), *Budget success hinges on execution and policy clarity*, including the Bankers Association's budget response. Article.

Currency amounts are as published. Conclusions, ratings and scenarios are the report's analysis. They are not statements by the Central Bank of Trinidad and Tobago, TT-CSIRT, any bank or any other institution.